

So overall, in terms of performance I didn't find anything substantial in the Google Pixel 8. Be it how powerful the smartphone is, or how seamlessly the AI tools and features work. There are issues with some of the most basic features like Bluetooth connectivity or calling. The smartphone has major heating issues, and the standby time is not good.

CAMERA

Where the Pixel 8 lacks in terms of the performance, the smartphone more than makes up in the camera game. This year, we get a slightly improved camera with a larger f/1.7 aperture as compared to the f/1.9 aperture on the Pixel 7's primary 50-megapixel shooter. The images out of this camera, as you'd expect from a Google Pixel are amazing. The details are sharp, the photos are accurate and of course, look super vibrant.

Again, Google has killed it with the camera all over again this time around. The images don't look the best when you're clicking them in the viewfinder, but the once you're done and Google's algorithm does its thing, the photos are just outstanding. Compared to the Apple iPhone, the images look a bit more saturated, but that is something that many people prefer in their smartphones. I honestly like how sharp and vibrant the images on this smartphone are. This time, Google has tuned the 50-megapixel camera much better and the difference is evident.

Like always, the image quality from the primary shooter is consistent with the wide angle lens, and yes, this is a Google Pixel so of course, the portraits are epic! Like I have said been saying since the past few years, no one does portraits better than Pixel smartphones. The portraits retain details in your skin, manage skin tones very nicely, along with the best edge detection and background blur in the game.

Pair these camera chops with Google's camera smarts and you have a winner at hand! This time, Google has gone even further with the AI implementations in the camera department. We get newer features like Best Take, which comes as a very nice and clean solution for fixing all your group photos in the future.

There is AI Noise reduction which cancels out the outside noise in your video, so you don't need to worry about ambient noise while recording videos in which someone is speaking, and the best (or most controversial) of all, Magic Editor, which basically allows you to move and change things in a photo as per your wish.

There are other features. For example, we get Google's "Bokeh Video" which is the cinematic video feature on the Pixel 8. We also get the option of not only adjusting the exposure while clicking photos, we can also change the colour tone and white balance in the photos while clicking them.

BATTERY

Coming to battery, here again the Google Pixel 8 is underwhelming. Now, while I was able to pull more than five hours of on-screen time on the Google Pixel 8 easily, the battery still doesn't feel very reliable.

I'll come to the worst part first, the standby time. The Google Pixel 8 has one of the worse stand-by times on any flagship. There are times when I go to sleep at more than 10 percent battery after putting my phone down, and I still wake up to a dead smartphone. Not good. I have, in the past said similar stuff about the horrible stand-by times on Samsung smartphones, but the Google Pixel 8 is at the same level as some of the Samsung phones that I have tested this year (barring the yet-to-be-reviewed S23 FE). Apart from this, while playing games, the Google Pixel 8 does a good job in sustaining the battery. While playing Call of Duty Mobile on the highest graphics, the smartphone lost about 4 percent battery in 15 minutes and about 10 percent battery in a 30-minute gaming session. This is decent for a smartphone with a 4,575mAh battery.

However, there are times when the device drains battery too fast. GPS navigation, i've realised guzzles the battery. The Google Pixel 8 lost close to 10 percent of the battery while using GPS navigation for an hour, and I noticed the smartphone draining battery at an even faster rate once things start to heat up. And yes, GPS navigation also heats up the phone quite a bit.

The charging is also slow. Here we get 27W fast charging which took about

2 hours and 20 minutes to charge the 4,575mAh battery from 0 to 100 percent. So overall, the battery on the Google Pixel 8 is underwhelming to say the least. The heating issues with the phone also lead to a lot of battery drain, but there is also the Google AI which understands the user's behaviour to optimise the battery and maybe using the smartphone for a couple of weeks is not enough for that to kick in, but until now, I'm not impressed with the battery performance.

VERDICT

So that was my review of the Google Pixel 8. One of the launches that I was most excited about has turned out to be a bit of a disappointment if I'm being honest. Yes, we get new AI tools and features and the Google Pixel's camera remains as good as we know it with new AI-based features that make things extra sweet and lucrative. Plus, this year we are also getting one of the best displays that we have seen on any Pixel smartphone.

However, the lack of power, the heating issues and the plethora of bugs in this smartphone don't give me enough confidence to call this a good upgrade. On top of all this, is Google's unreliable after sales service support in the country. All of this combined, does not make me want to recommend the smartphone for new buyers since Rs 75,999 is a lot of money to spend on something that lacks refinement and after sale service.

—Darab Mansoor Ali

SPECIFICATIONS

BODY: Dimensions: 150.5 x 70.8 x 8.9 mm | Weight: 87 g | IP68 dust/water resistant (up to 1.5m for 30 min) | **DISPLAY:** Type: OLED, 120Hz, HDR10+, 1400 nits (HBM), 2000 nits (peak) | Size: 6.2 inches, 91.1 cm² | Resolution: 1080 x 2400 pixels, 20:9 ratio | **PLATFORM:** OS: Android 14 | Chipset: Google Tensor G3 (4 nm) | CPU: Nona-core | **MEMORY:** Internal: 128GB 8GB RAM, 256GB 8GB RAM, UFS 3.1 | **MAIN CAMERA:** Dual: 50 MP, f/1.7, 25mm (wide), | 12 MP, f/2.2, 126° (ultrawide), 1/2.9", 1.25µm, AF | **SELFIE CAMERA:** Single: 10.5 MP, f/2.2, 20mm (ultrawide), 1/3.1", 1.22µm | Features: Auto-HDR, panorama | Video: 4K@24/30/60fps, 1080p@30/60fps

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